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## // The most affected victims of computer hazards are children //

over the years. Capillaries carry blood to muscles and tendons. As tense muscles squeeze (like when bending the finger or the wrist), blood flow to the affected area slows down. When the blood flow stops, a muscle has enough energy stored to cope with the tension for a brief while. Once this is expended, the muscle switches to an inefficient form of energy supply. Once this too is over, lactic acid builds up in the muscle, causing pain and fatigue. In a reflex reaction called the splinting reaction, the neighbouring muscles tense up, triggering a self-sustaining pain cycle. The pain can also migrate from one part of the limb to another. Over time, the strained muscles turn hyper-sensitive and develop specific tender points called myofascial trigger points. The inadequate blood sup-

ply causes numbness and tingling. On account of larger nerves being squeezed, the tingling and numbness is more defined.

The tell-tale signs of RSI are pain, stiffness, swelling, numbness and tingling in the hands, wrists, elbows, shoulders, back or neck. RSI is common not only among those who use the PC, but also those who employ long periods of steady hand movement, such as musicians and sportspeople. It is common with work that demands repetitive grasping, turning and twisting, like while using the computer keyboard or operating a power tool. Stressful wrist and neck positions, as those faced by desk workers, serve only to aggravate the potential for damage.

### Prevention better than cure

With computers becoming an integral part of our work implements, prevention is the only course. Denial of the early-stage symptoms, according to Dr Nela-pana, is one of the main causes that aggravates the condition. Precautionary measures need to be interwoven into our daily lifestyle and methods of working. This is where ergonomic devices come in. These devices are specially designed under medical observation to reduce stress upon the concerned body part and reduce the chances, if not prevent the possibility of any injury. While awareness of the benefits of using, say, an ergonomic mouse or keyboard is not widespread, most dealers stock the whole gamut of devices.

Mr Sandeep Parasrampur, director of BestIt, a vendor of ergonomic devices affirms, saying, "No one comes in looking specifically for an ergonomic device. The health benefits have to be pointed out as one of the additional features." (See box, 'Ergonomic devices'.)

Another precaution, which is ignored as much as it is stressed upon, is to develop a healthy lifestyle and work environment. A balanced diet, regular exercise, proper ventilation, and breaks to stretch and give the eyes some rest go a long way in letting us savour our working moments.

The line between dedication and addiction is a fine one and can be easily crossed. While technology continues to open new frontiers, it brings with it newer hazards. Just as with life, the universe and everything beyond, the beige box needs a healthy serving of salt. 

RACHANA SANGHANI AND MITALI PAREKH

### Keep your Eyes Open



**You need to see the doctor if you have...**

- Persistent pain or spasms in the wrist and fingers that spreads to the arms, especially the one you use the most, that is, right arm for right-handers and left arm for left-handers.
- Tenderness and pain in the neck, shoulder, upper back, upper arm, elbow, forearm, wrist or fingers.
- Swelling of hands or forearms.
- Difficulty using your hands for general tasks and experience loss of grip.
- Unusual sensations that may include numbness, tingling, stiffness, very cold sensations, tremors and burning in the fingers, hands, wrists, elbows or arms.
- Decreased sensitivity and motor control in your fingers, hands, wrists, elbows or arms.
- Sudden locking up or freezing of fingers, hands, wrists or elbows.
- Tired, aching, heavy, red, watery and irritated eyes.
- Blurring and loss of focus.
- Insomnia, fatigue and if any of these symptoms cause you to wake up at night.

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